



INVESTING WITHOUT PANIC

Narrated by Rocky

A MONKEYMONEY COLLECTION



My name is Rocky. I've played guitar in a rock band since I was fifteen, and I learned to invest around the same time I learned to walk on stage without my legs shaking.

The day I learned the most about investing wasn't a calm one. It was a day the market dropped hard — one of those days when the news talks about “panic” and “collapse” — and my investment account lost, in a few hours, more than I make in two months of playing bars.

I felt the immediate urge to sell everything. Pull the money out, get it somewhere safe, stop looking at the screen. It was the exact same instinct I used to feel at my early shows when something went wrong live: stop, run, hide.

But I learned, on stages first and in the market later, that stopping in the middle of chaos is almost always the worst possible moment to do it. That night I kept playing even when the stage lights went out. That day, I didn't sell anything.

Months later, that same market had fully recovered, and so had my money. If I had sold in a panic that day, I would have turned a temporary dip into a real, permanent loss.

This book is everything I learned about investing without letting panic make the decisions for me. I'm not going to talk to you in bank jargon. I'm going to tell it to you the way I understood it: with noise, with nerves, and with the calm that gets built over time.



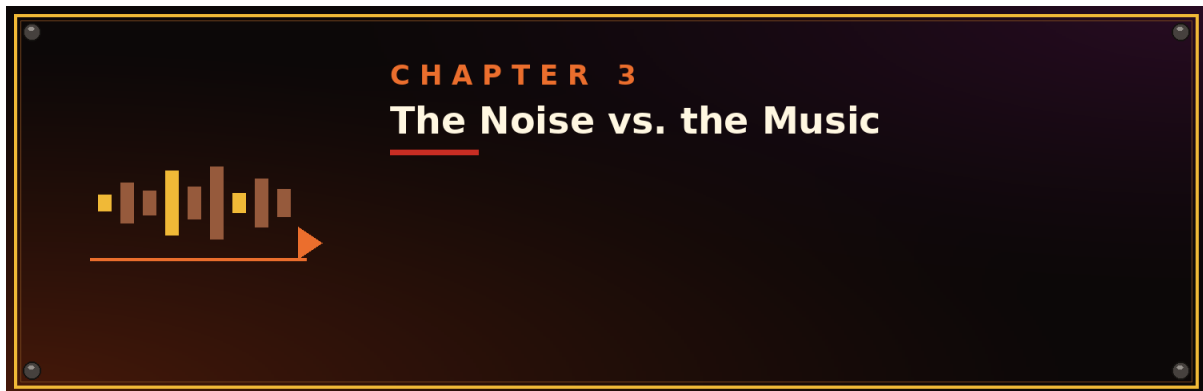
The first thing I had to understand is that investing and gambling have nothing to do with each other, even though they sometimes feel similar.

When you gamble, the outcome depends almost entirely on chance. Rolling a die has no connection to anything real; you simply win or lose based on luck.

When you invest in something real — like a piece of a company that sells products, has employees, generates revenue — the outcome is connected to something that actually exists in the world. It's not guaranteed, but it's not pure chance either.

The confusion comes from the fact that both have short-term uncertainty. A die and a stock can both “surprise” you from one day to the next. But while a die never stops being random, a real, solid company, given enough time, tends to reflect what it's actually worth.

I learned that the difference isn't whether there's uncertainty — there always is — but whether you're putting your money into something with real value behind it, and whether you're giving it enough time for that value to show.



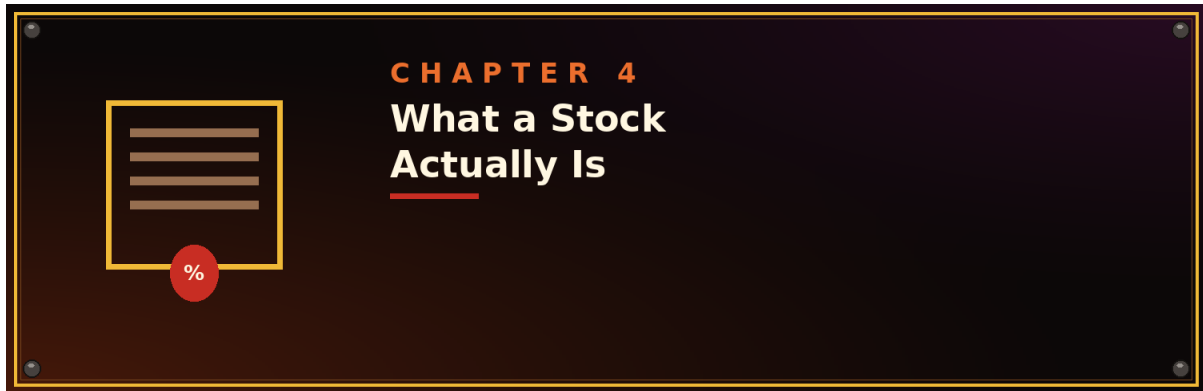
At a live show there's a ton of noise: people shouting, lights changing, someone hitting a wrong note during soundcheck. But the music — the actual song — is still there underneath all of it.

The market works exactly the same way. Every day there's noise: an alarming headline, a rumor, a 2% drop that sounds like the end of the world on the news. That's short-term noise.

The music — what actually matters — is how a company or an economy performs over years, not over one day. Solid companies, in general, generate more value over time, no matter how much noise happens along the way.

My mistake, early on, was checking my investment account every single day, and confusing every small move with an important signal. It was like trying to judge an entire song based on half a second of sound.

I learned to ask myself, every time I saw a drop: is this just noise from a bad day, or is it a real sign that something fundamental changed? Most of the time, it was just noise.



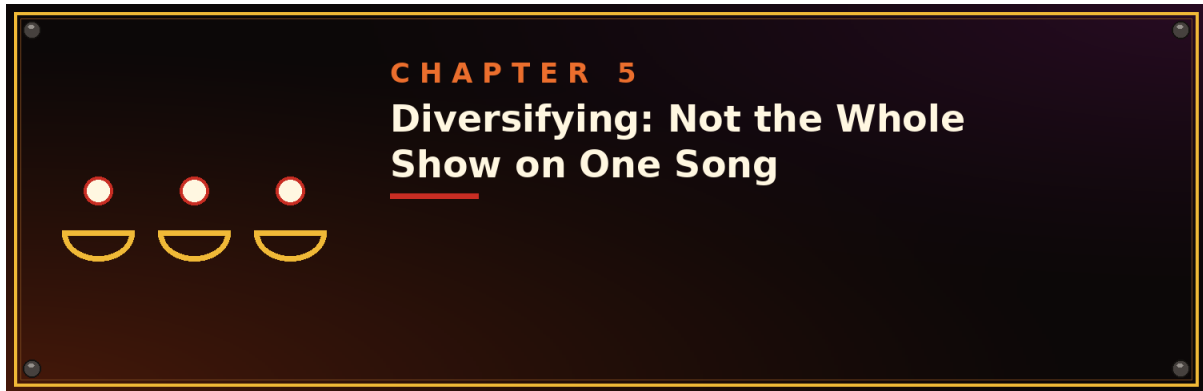
For a long time I thought “buying a stock” was like buying a lottery ticket with a company's name on it. I had no idea what I was actually buying.

A stock is, literally, a small piece of a real company. If I buy a share of a company that sells sneakers, I become the owner of a tiny slice of that business: its factories, its brands, its future profits.

When that company sells more, earns more money, or becomes more valuable, my small piece becomes worth more too. When it does poorly, my piece loses value too.

This completely changed how I think about my investments. I stopped asking “will it go up or down tomorrow?” as if it were a roulette wheel. I started asking: “will this company still be selling, still be generating value, five or ten years from now?”

Seeing a stock as a real little piece of a business, instead of just a number moving up and down on a screen, was what helped me most to stop reacting out of fear.



In my band, after one disastrous show, we learned that you can't depend on a single song to carry the whole set. If that one song fails — a string breaks, someone messes up — the whole show goes down with it.

The same thing happens with investing. If I put all my money into a single company, my outcome depends entirely on what happens to that one company. If it does badly, I lose everything.

Diversifying means spreading my money across many different companies, from different sectors, even different countries. That way, if one “song” goes wrong, the others can carry the rest of the show.

It's not about having a hundred random investments with no logic behind them. It's about not betting everything on a single story, no matter how safe it feels in the moment.

Once I truly diversified, I stopped panicking whenever a single company in my portfolio had a bad month. The rest of the band kept playing.



CHAPTER 6

The Power of Time on Stage

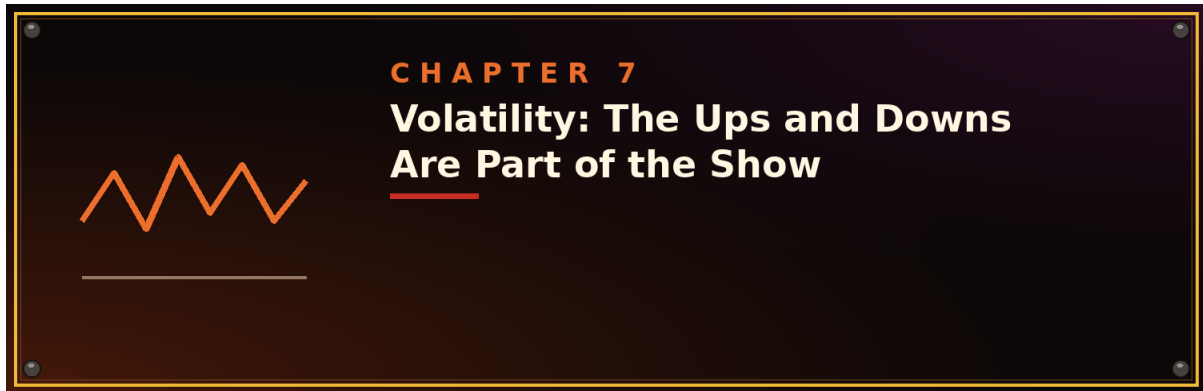
When I started playing in small bars, I made almost nothing per show. But I kept getting on stage, week after week, for years, before the band actually started sounding like something.

With investing I discovered the same pattern: time is the most powerful ingredient I have, more powerful than any short-term stroke of luck.

One dollar invested today, left to grow for twenty years, can become far more than a dollar invested for just two years, even if that second dollar had a better return in the moment. Time lets the ups and downs average out, and lets the real growth of companies build up.

I also learned about investing a little bit every month, regardless of whether the market is up or down that day — a technique some people call “dollar-cost averaging.” Some months I buy more expensive, some months cheaper, and over time it balances itself out.

It's just like music: it's not about playing one perfect note a single time. It's about showing up and playing, consistently, for years.



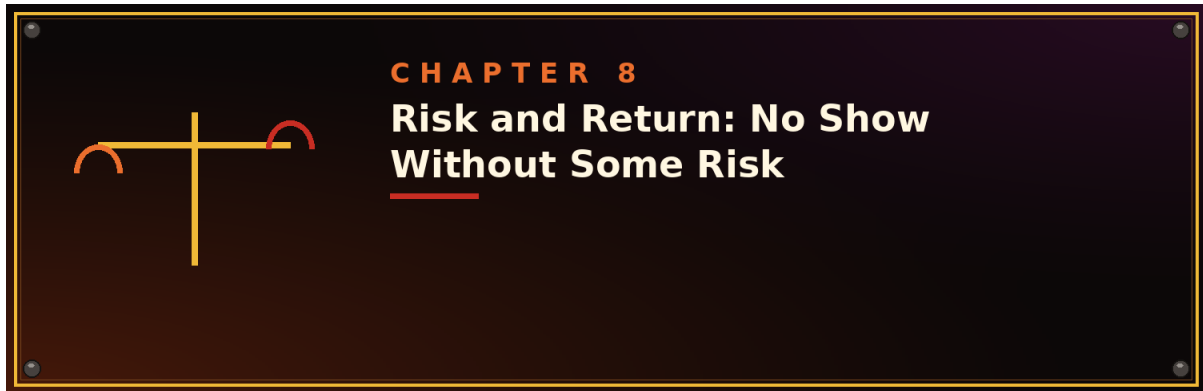
No live concert is a perfectly straight line. There are moments of huge energy, slow stretches, even awkward silences between songs. That's a normal part of the show, not a sign that something went wrong.

The market is the same: it goes up and down constantly, even in years that end up being strongly positive overall. That's called volatility, and it's completely normal — not a system failure.

My mistake, early on, was thinking every dip meant something was broken, and every rally meant I had already “made it.” Neither one was true on its own.

I learned to see volatility as the background noise of any long concert: it's always there, it goes up and down, and it doesn't define whether the show, as a whole, was good or bad.

Accepting that ups and downs are a normal part of the path — not an exception — was what helped me most to stop running whenever the market got noisy.



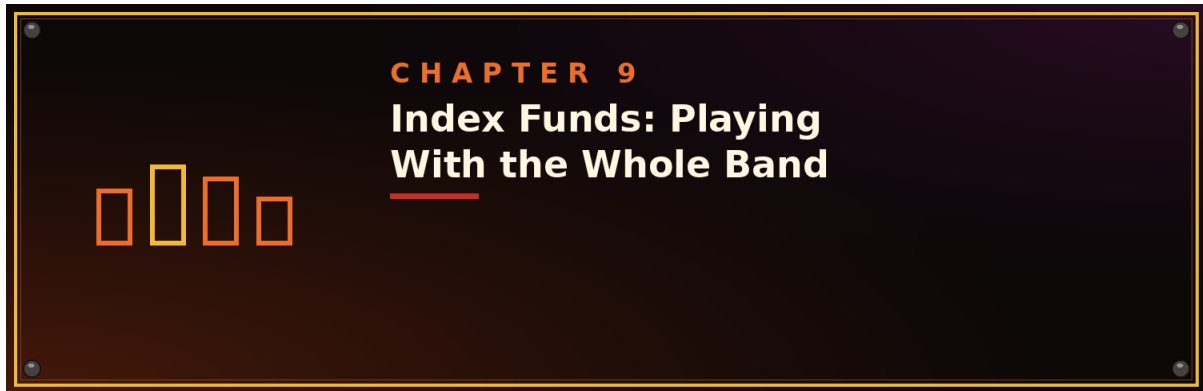
I've never seen a concert with zero risk: there's always a chance something goes wrong live. But I've also never seen a great concert without that risk — it's part of what makes it real and exciting.

Something similar happens with money. Keeping all your money under the mattress, with zero risk, almost guarantees that money loses value over time due to inflation. Investing in something with more growth potential always comes with a bit more uncertainty.

The key thing I learned isn't “avoid all risk,” but understanding how much risk I'm willing to accept, in exchange for how much growth I expect over time.

The “calmer” investments tend to grow more slowly but more steadily. The more “intense” ones can grow more, but with bigger swings along the way.

There's no single recipe. There's just the right question: how much noise can I tolerate along the way, in exchange for what result down the road?



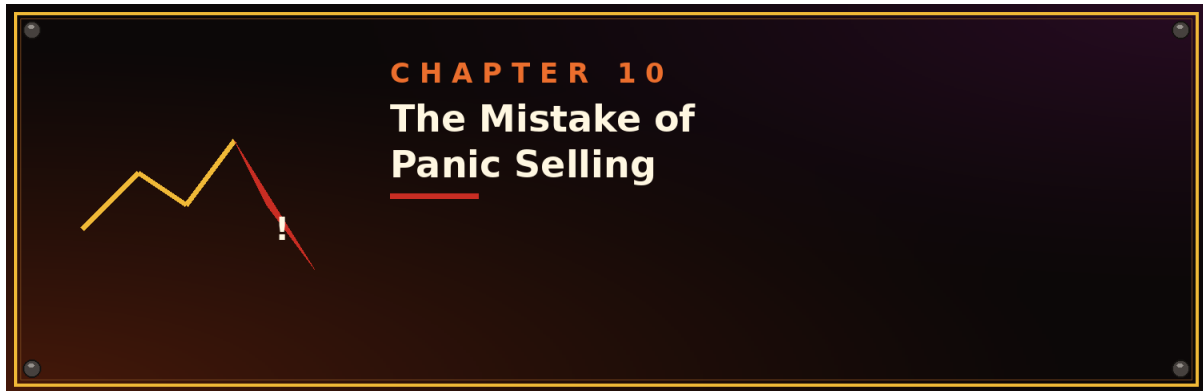
For a while I tried “playing solo,” picking individual companies one by one, trying to guess which ones would go up the most. Sometimes I got it right. Many times I didn't.

Then I discovered index funds: instead of betting on a single company, this kind of fund automatically spreads your money across hundreds or thousands of different companies at once.

It's like playing with the whole band instead of trying to carry an entire show alone with one guitar. If one company in the fund does poorly, there are hundreds of others holding up the overall result.

These funds also tend to have lower costs than constantly trying to pick stocks one by one, and over time, for most people, they end up delivering very solid results without needing to spend all day analyzing companies.

I never stopped admiring people who pick individual stocks with real knowledge. But for me, playing with the whole band turned out to be the calmest, most consistent way to build my own financial show.



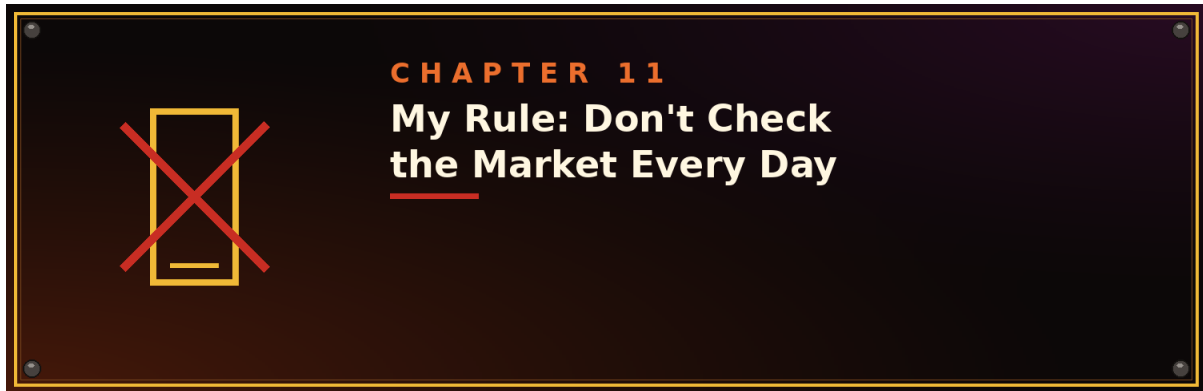
The most expensive mistake I made in my early investing years wasn't picking a bad investment. It was selling in a panic during a sharp drop, only to watch the market recover weeks later — without me.

I sold because I couldn't stand watching the number go down every day. I bought back in a few months later, once it had already gone up quite a bit, feeling “safe” again.

In simple terms: I sold low, out of fear, and bought back high, out of relief. That's exactly the opposite of what's supposed to happen if you want to make money investing.

I understood that panic isn't just an uncomfortable feeling — it has a real, measurable cost when we let it make financial decisions for us.

Ever since, whenever I feel the urge to sell everything in the middle of a drop, I ask myself a simple question: did something real and fundamental actually change, or am I just reacting to the noise of one bad night on stage?



After that mistake, I had to set myself a rule that was hard to follow at first: stop checking my investment account every day.

Checking it daily made every small dip feel like a personal crisis, and every small rally feel like a win I had to “protect” by selling. Neither reaction actually helped me.

Now I check my account once a month, on the same day, no exceptions. That's enough to notice if something truly important changed, and rare enough that daily noise doesn't get to control me.

This rule has, literally, protected my money over the long run more than any single stock pick I've ever made.

Not checking the market every day isn't ignorance. It's discipline. It's the financial version of not running off stage every time someone yells something from the crowd.



With everything I learned, I put together a simple plan I still follow today. I'll share it with you exactly as I use it:

Step 1: Understand what you're buying. Don't invest in anything you can't explain in your own words.

Step 2: Actually diversify. Don't bet everything on one company, sector, or country.

Step 3: Give it time. Think in years, not days or weeks.

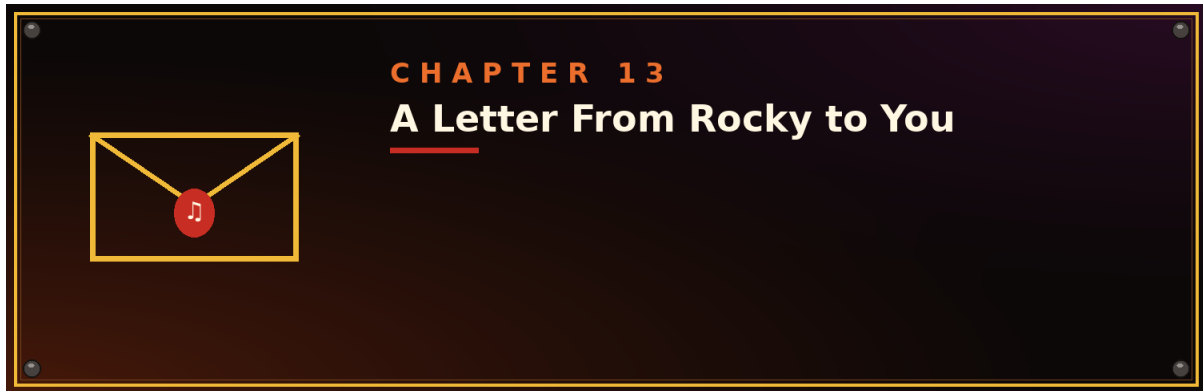
Step 4: Consider index funds if you'd rather play with the whole band than go it alone.

Step 5: Accept volatility as a normal part of the road, not a warning sign.

Step 6: Check your account rarely, on fixed dates, not every time there's an alarming headline.

Step 7: Before selling during a drop, ask yourself if something real changed, or if it's just noise.

This plan doesn't remove uncertainty. But it gives you solid ground to stand on, even when everything around you sounds loud and chaotic.



If you've made it this far, you already know what it took me the loudest noise to learn: the worst possible moment to make a financial decision is almost always in the middle of a panic.

I won't lie to you: there are days when watching your investment drop is genuinely scary. It still happens to me. The difference is that now I know that fear doesn't get to make the decision for me.

Investing without panic doesn't mean feeling nothing. It means you keep playing, keep following the plan, even when part of you wants to run off the stage.

I started with an out-of-tune guitar and a market that crashed right when I was most nervous. You can start today, with whatever you have, understanding that time and calm are worth more than any gut reaction on a bad day.

I'm not asking you to never feel afraid. I still do too. But every time I chose not to sell in a panic, I learned something no book had ever explained to me before.

So here's my question for you: the next time the market gets loud, are you going to run off the stage, or are you going to keep playing?

Turn it up. Keep playing. I'll be right here, guitar in hand, not moving from this stage with you.

— *Rocky*